

Free Software Solutions for a Secure Online Workplace



Image source <https://blog.infeedo.com>

The COVID-19 pandemic has made working online from home the new normal. The Internet being what it is, with numerous players interacting with it (including some who are malicious), security plays a critical role. This article focuses on free software solutions that will enable privacy, security and data protection during the pandemic and in the post-COVID era.

In recent times, the expression ‘Privacy-first by design’ has gained attention. The General Data Protection Regulation or GDPR is a standard adopted by the European Union, ensuring the privacy and data protection of its citizens. Many hosting platforms like *hetzner.com* and *scaleway.com* provide GDPR based cloud hosting services. This has gained more attention among the Indian public after the protests by free software activists against the Arogya Sethu app, which was subsequently made free software with access for auditing. The public now has greater awareness about data protection and privacy related matters, as well as the many services and software that offer privacy-friendly replacements to commonly used proprietary services. So let’s discuss some of these online services and programs that ensure privacy, security

and data protection, with a focus on the online digital workplace.

CryptPad, a replacement for Google Docs or Office Online

CryptPad is an online document editing service, similar to Google Docs and Office Online, without the privacy issues. It encrypts the data as you type, which ensures that your data cannot be accessed by anyone else. This service is a good choice for government firms and privacy conscious users.

In order to use CryptPad, go straight to <https://cryptpad.fr/index.html> and select your pad, which is the term used to specify the various available editors. Listed below are the many pads that the service has to offer:

- Rich Text – A collaborative word processor
- Code – You can do collaborative coding here

- Presentation – A PowerPoint alternative
- Poll – A poll creation tool
- Kanban – A to-do list creator
- Whiteboard – A drawing board
- CryptDrive – Storage for your pads (You get 50MB for free. It is now 1GB for registered users on account of the COVID-19 situation.)
- Sheet – An Excel alternative that is in the beta stage (It requires a sign-up to use.)

All pads support auto-save and file uploading (saved in your CryptDrive). CryptPad also supports collaboration, which means you can co-author documents with other people in real-time. There is a chat section available in the side bar, which you can use to communicate with your collaborators.

Sharing a link using the built-in option allows you to grant the user read-only or editing privileges. You

